more determined stand, I have submitted to any action that you eventually decided.'[30]

Nevertheless, despite his protestations that Nehru had never met any obstruction or opposition from any of his Cabinet colleagues in the making of foreign policy, Patel did take the opportunity – both at the meeting and in his letter – to obliquely, but also incisively, critique its broader framework. In explaining away the dismal performance of India's diplomatic outreach abroad, when compared to Pakistan, as an inevitable outcome of explaining their moral position to an opportunistic world, he subtly but firmly challenged the intellectual foundations of Nehruvian internationalism. He illustrated this by pointing at concrete instances: the recognition of the People's Republic of China (the haste of which Patel had cautioned against) had alienated Nationalist China, Indian antipathy to the recognition of the Bao Dai regime in Vietnam was bound to alienate the West, and the delay in the recognition of Israel was bound to cost them the goodwill of Israel and the countries interested in it.

Many of these points were echoed by Ambedkar in his resignation speech on 10 October 1951, when he contended that India was ploughing a lonely furrow in the world, and its foreign policy, the policy of trying to do the impossible and be too good, had left it friendless and isolated – unable to get food for its starving millions, aid for its industrial development or military support in the face of threats to its security.[31]

Patel's riposte to Nehru on 28 March demonstrates that foreign policy was a major bone of contention and disharmony within the Cabinet, even if Patel himself deliberately shied away from confrontation and allowed Nehru a free hand. Furthermore, it outlined the conceptual challenge to the Nehruvian worldview that was taking shape in the minds of Patel and many other detractors as they came to recognize its pitfalls. Patel's recognition that the failure of India's diplomatic outreach was closely related to the broader thrust of India's foreign policy and constrained its ability to counter Pakistan marked a significant milestone within the Indian establishment. And finally, the exchange of letters in March provides crucial contextual